A Long and Exceptionally Exciting Journey

Written By Matt D

Chapter 1

Every punch hurts worse than the blow before. My name is Philip; I am a shopkeeper's son in the town of Hazelwood. All the other kids at school either don't like me, or like Father says they're just jealous of me. Well then why would they chase me every day and beat me up! He just wants me to feel better about it all, and I don't blame him either. The school kids, all seven of them, chase me through town, throwing rocks at me the whole time. They all start to split up, maybe for good today. I look ahead; there are two exits, the turn to my left, and the turn to my right. I can't go straight because it's the town dock, I'd be trapped. I turn to my right and the kids that separated are standing there, laughing mockingly. I turn around to go the left exit, but to no good, I'm already trapped. I run down the dock, hoping something good will happen. The kids slowly walk towards me, I want to jump in but the current is so powerful it wouldn't do me any good. The kids seem to recognize my worry, because they pick me up and toss me into the Big River, and then they run away, hoping nobody saw what they did. I try to swim but the current is too strong. I look for a way to climb out, there's nothing. I start to panic, and while I'm wildly thrashing my arms I brush my hand against some rope. Some rope, I look back and there's rope sitting along the water up to the edge of the town. I grab hold of the rope and manage to pull myself out, but afterwards I am as weak as a Forgon. Forgons live alongside the Big River, up near the mountain; they feast on fungus and smaller creatures. They are really small, about the size of your thumb. The Big River flows from the top of the mountain that lies to the north; it flows right through Hazelwood and travels south to the great city of Malcore, where all the merchants and shops are. Every few years Father and I visit Malcore for a few weeks, gathering the many supplies we will need back at the shop.

I run as fast as I can and make it home about an hour or so later than usual. Father is upset,

"Where were you Philip?"

"They threw me into the river again Father,"

Father stops whatever it was he was doing and stares at me,

"And you didn't fight back?"

I look to the ground, trying to hide from his disappointment like a mouse from an owl.

"No Father,"

He walks towards me, puts his arms on my shoulders, and quietly but very powerfully says,

"I specifically told you to fight back next time!"

I take a step back, breaking his reach,

"But Father! I can't fight! You know I am not a fighter!"

"Well, you are going to start to become one if these kids keep chasing you. Go into your room and change into some dry clothes ok?"

"Alright Father,"

I walk up the stairs into the top floor, where my room lays hidden behind a large, wooden door. I step in,

and get dressed in clean, dry clothes. I then travel down the wooden stairs to the kitchen, where Father has supper all prepared on the table. Mushroom stew with cabbage, one of my favourites. I can tell he is trying to make me feel better. I meet him halfway.

“Thank you Father for supper,”

“Hey I know what your favourite supper is don’t I? Have you heard the news?”

I look on Father’s face, he looks concerned.

“No they don’t really say the news in school, what is it?”

“They say a giant has left the mountain, he’s wandering in the forest,”

Father was always quiet. Never raised his voice, or yelled, but if he was serious you would be able to tell. He would also always be hearing the news of orcs, trolls, centaurs, giants, dragons, and other really interesting beasts, probably because at one point he hunted them. When he was younger he was a Slayer, that’s what they were called back then, they don’t exist anymore. They slayed great beasts and actually saved the land from an awful dragon, they called him Cartivoree, he was a grand dragon. Cartivoree actually rallied up an army of orcs to attack mankind, probably to annihilate the human race. Father was one of the men who survived the battle. But before he could return the orc raids had already passed his town, killing everyone, even Mother. He quit the guild, and at a good time because after that the guild separated until it was just ashes of a great community.

“Do they know what this giant can do? Or where it's going?”

“No. We don’t know anything about this giant,”

“Well, that makes me even more certain to never enter the woods!”

Father sighs and continues eating,

“Son sometime you are going to have to explore that place one day, I know you don’t like the outdoors but you have to control yourself. You are 15 and you need to be strong.”

“Yes Father, but I cannot do that yet. Maybe in a year or two but not today,”

“Well, if you can sleep a night without that lantern on, then maybe I'll think about not making you explore it for a while.”

“One year?”

“No, maybe a few months’ tops,”

“Ok Father,”

There was nothing else said that supper, and I slept with a lantern on as usual.

Chapter 2

Today is the day of Unkati; it's my day to run the shop. I love working in the shop. I can run a shop way better than anything the other kids can do.

“Hello boy, do you sell any arrows?”

I recognized that voice, I was turned around to stack books, and I turned to see my customer. I first noticed his worn out boots, with holes here and there. His hide coat from a winged beast was ripped and torn in too many places to count, and his blonde hair was covered with mud and hanging down past his shoulders. It was Aro Silvet, the best arrows man south of the borders of our land. He hunts in the wild and slays mystic creatures we couldn’t even imagine.

I stumbled for the right words, “Um, Mr. Silvet, yes we have arrows, umm, right over here sir.”

I pulled out a box with a bunch of arrows, “Finest in all of Hazelwood. Good luck finding any better within a hundred miles! Other than Malcore anyway,”

Mr. Silvet laughed, “Call me Aro, may I grasp one?”

His voice was, calmer than I recently imagined it to be.

“Of course sir,”

Aro held it up in his hands, did some fidgeting, and passed it back.

“Are the arrows all like this?”

“Yes sir, would you like to purchase a few?”

Aro smiled, “Of course. The quality is excellent. Where do you find arrows of this sort? These are better than all the arrows in Malcore tenfold!”

“An elf sold these ones here as he passed town,”

“Well that’s not surprising; elven arrows are always quite intriguing,”

He looked at me, “I would like to purchase all of them if I may.”

Right then Father came up and saw Aro,

“Well, hello sir Aro Silvet, I hope young Philip here has pleased you?”

Aro seemed surprized, “Yes he has! No doubt about it at all, he has a gift of marketing.”

Father looked exceptionally pleased, “Well he plans on it for his future, and he’s not too fond of the wilderness,”

Aro looked at me for a second, then back to Father, “He looks like a warrior to me. You said your son’s name is Philip?”

Father looked back to Aro, “Yes?”

Aro looked astonished, “A friend of mine was named Philip, and he was eaten by an Alcrog.”

Father and I have never heard of the creature Aro was talking about. It must've been obvious.

"It's a huge beast, something like a mix of a wolf and an eagle that creates havoc in deserts. It flies and can see very long distances, it also swallows men whole."

"I am so sorry to hear that."

Aro looked joyful, "Don't worry young Phillip, when he was engulfed he also slaughtered the Alcrog."

I quickly became really interested, "How so?"

Aro looked suddenly sorrowful, "When he was swallowed the Alcrog took flight. Philip cut out the beast's heart from the inside. He survived the fall, but bled to death before I could revive him. But he had accomplished one last thing; he died with its heart in his hands. The Alcrog is over my shoulder right now actually."

I turned more attention to his coat then to him buying arrows for a minute. His coat slung down his shoulders, like a cape. The Alcrogs mouth lay hidden behind Aro's head, but it didn't hide the fact that the Alcrogs mouth could swallow man whole with room to spare. The wings lay past his boots and dragged against the ground. The beast's arms were attached to Aro's arms with leather straps, making it possible to disguise himself as an Alcrog if he were to lie down on the grass.

Aro returned into his serious self again, bought all the elven arrows, and said something in elvish to Father, who said something back to Aro.

Father never spoke about what they talked about.

Chapter 3

The next day was fairly normal. Go to school, run home. Actually this day I managed to get home without being hurt too bad. When I got home Father was pleased.

“Hey Philip, you’re home on time today. What happened?”

“I just outran them I guess Father.”

Father chuckled to himself, “Well, that’s good news. I have some even better news for you,”

He’s so calm and serious all the time. So when Father says that he has good news, you know that it's going to be really good!

“Were going to go to Malcore tomorrow, make sure you’re all packed.”

We’re going to Malcore. Even though just last year we went?

“But Father, shouldn’t we go in a few years? Not now? We went already last year?”

“Do you want to question this? I feel that we need some time, away from everything. This town can be very, full. Do you understand?”

I was so excited I felt like I was going to jump as high as a Tilfor! The creature is about as big as our home, and has horns so large that in one battle it fell over because the horns are too heavy for it.

“Yes. I do understand. Thank you Father! I don’t know what else to say.”

“Well there’s no need for it, now were leaving at first light so be absolutely sure that you have everything you need. Do you have any spare coin?”

“I have twelve Father,”

“Ok wait here for a minute,”

Father left for a while, and I kept thinking on why Father would want to leave town. Hazelwood is a remarkable town. But before long he returned with a small box, he very delicately set it down on the table. It was a small, wooden box that was locked with a very secure lock mechanism. Its hinges were very unique, probably a dwarvish box by the looks of it.

“I believe that now is the time for you to open this. It was a gift for me when I left the Slayers.”

Father then went into his pocket, and pulled out a small key. He unlocked the box, but then locked it back up, and stuffed the key in his pocket.

“I’m thinking it will be a better gift once we’re in Malcore,”

He picked up the box, and went into his room. I went into my room, quite frustrated that Father would leave me in such tense disappointment, and started to pack.

Little did I know that the next day will be a very, very long day.

I awaken to the sound of birds chirping, and Father hustling about throwing bags and box’s out the door. Father notices I'm awake and quietly says,

“Hurry boy, it's shortly after dawn and we need to leave now if we’re going to make it.”

“Yes Father,”

I hurry and get my bag from underneath my cot, which includes books to read on the trip, coin, and other goods I might need. Father gets the horses ready, making sure that they are attached to the wagon, while I get up in the passengers spot. Father jumps in and starts at the reins, and we start off on our journey.

The trip is a long and very, very boring expedition. The only exciting part is when we stopped to water the horses in a nearby pond, and that wasn’t even exciting. After that it was all a, what can I do to not bore myself. I actually read about half a book before I fell asleep.

When I awaken I look to my right, there’s Father, hauling at the reins.

“Father, its noon correct?”

Father looks up at the sky for a minute, and then looks back to the road in front of him.

“Yes, a little past noon, remember when the school accidently thought you were ahead of class, and didn’t teach you how to tell time because they thought you already knew how?”

I laugh, that year was crazy, Father had to complain that I hadn’t learned how to tell time, for I excelled in math and they assumed I was past it.

“Yeah, how can I forget?”

We turn a right and roll up to a cliff edge, Father slows down and I lose my balance a little. The cliff edge extends downwards and curves right. To the left is a steep wall of rock that slopes down to an open field, a few hundred lengths fall at least.

“I've managed to figure it out on my own. I don’t think the school needs to teach me.”

“What if we look and find you a short, affordable class in Malcore?”

“I don’t think it’s necessary, you could test me and-“

SNAP! Both Father and I turn back to see where the sound emanated from. It happens again, CRACK! We both know where it came from as part of the wagon breaks off and rolled a little before tumbling down the cliff. Father tries to turn the wagon but as he does so, another crack comes as the other side of the wagon breaks off. The wagon swerves to the left, in the direction of the steep edge! Father grabs me and tries to push me out but it's too late, the wagon falls, tumbles, turns, and breaks down the steep ledge, with Father and I in the front seat. There's a lot of crashing and thrashing and all I see is a blur of grey and brown as bits of dirt and small rocks hit me all over the face.

I remember nothing after this.

Chapter 4

I awaken.

I can see nothing except blinding light, I have no idea how I got here. I try to stand up, but I'm so weak I just fall back down on the grass like a puppet. My head is filled with a small, but annoying ring. I feel the sweat dripping down my face and onto the soaking collar of my shirt. The knees of my pants are ripped, torn and feel like I've worn them for years. My hair sags down my face, and drips even more sweat. I look up and down my arm, there are cuts and scratches all through them, and the sleeves are gone. I take a second and feel the grass; it's so soft how the grass slithers right through my hand like sand on the beach. Pain rips through my hand and curls up my arm. I flip it out in the air and hold it up to my face. It's red, very red. “OW!” I look to where the pain came from. The light diminishes as a blur of red and orange come into view. I can see fire? Where did the fire come from? The ringing in my head stops and I can hear more fire behind me. I turn my head as far back as I can, only to see a bonfire the size of a small house. I struggle to stand again, but even with all my strength I can only manage to climb up to my knees before I slunk down again.

I turn away from the fire and look ahead of me, it's a huge blur of green and brown all warped, twisted, and altered together. I strain my eyes to focus more on the blur. As it clarifies I gaze in bewilderment as I recognize that I am in an enormous forest. I turn back to the fire and observe that it looks familiar. I crawl towards the wreckage, only to notice something even more recognizable, I see someone. The person is just lying on his stomach next to the wreckage, I start to inch myself over to him. The closer I get the more I know this person, man. I struggle through boxes and bags, until I get closer to this man. As I hover over him, feeling like my legs might crumple down and shatter any second. I just have the strength to lift up his arm and turn him over to his backside, I fall and lay beside this man for a minute before I get back up on my knees again and recognize him.

It's Father.

Chapter 5

Instantly I remember what happened! There was a wagon crash and Father and I must have fallen out and onto the field or else we would've been crushed by the plunging wagon. I feel a sudden burst of energy as adrenaline scurries through my veins. I grab Father's legs, and start to drag him out of the wreckage area and towards the forest, but as I do I remember the box, the very small box that Father was going to give me in Malcore. I let Father down a good twenty lengths away from the fire, and dash as fast as I can towards the outer edge of the wreckage; I look thoroughly in every box, bag, nook and cranny until I realize the box must be in the wreckage. The only good thing is that dwarven boxes, if it is a dwarven box, they can't burn up. I look up ahead to the sun; it's not where I remember it to be. I look around myself and my surroundings; I see trees, lots of trees. There is a slope that heads straight up, too steep to climb. To my left, I believe south, a great storm is approaching. It won't be long until its right above my head. And storms in our country are very perilous so it would be wise to get to shelter before it arrives.

I turn my attention back to the wreckage, the fire is diminishing. I sit and wait for a while until it looks safe enough to enter through compartments. I tip-toe through burned crates and rags, until I find a box that's still in one piece. I reach my hand for the first box, but it falls apart and crumples onto my hand, my arm immediately sends waves of pain through my body; I pull it back, grasp it, and try to calm myself down, but to no good because my heart is pounding faster than the fastest horse in the country! I look around in the wreckage for cloth or something to wrap around my arm. If there was any cloth here, it's all burned up. I try to rip off part of my shirt, it's too strong. Even though it's all burned and scraped it's still thick cloth. As I struggle with this shirt that's already been through enough today I see a small twinkle from the corner of my eye. I look back to where it came from; in between two pieces of burned wood I see a small handle! I run towards the box that so draws my attention, only to remember that the wood is still almost like charcoal. I run to the tree line and grab the first few sticks I find and return to the box. I grab the first wooden plank and try to lift it by one end and lower it a few feet away from the box; it breaks into a few pieces and scatters a little ways. I then turn to the last plank of wood that is keeping me from that box. I very slowly and carefully raise the other plank and move it away from the box. I stop for a second, staring at the box. Its hinges look brand new, like years before Father ever got it. The handle glistened like ancient gold.

I pick up the dwarven box, it's incredibly heavy. I manage to lift it higher than my waist and drag it towards Father, a few more lengths away. As I set it down on the grass I look for the sun, wherever it may be. I can't find it, but I can feel the heat of it pouring down the left side of my face. I stretch in the unseen sunlight, but as I lift my arms in the air I see a little red on my shirt. I lower my arms and stroke the side of my face with my hand, I retrieve it and examine the hand is covered in blood. Immediately my head aches so dreadfully I kneel down on the grass. I lift my hand up the river flowing from my head, searching for the opening. I notice that my hair isn't dripping of sweat, but of blood. I start to feel fatigued. The adrenaline is leaving me, I can feel it. I am petrified. I am in a huge dense forest with nothing but me, Father, and this box. Nothing to eat, and surly nothing to sleep in, I am going to die. The beasts of the wild can kill me for all I care. See what I say when they come prowling for a decent meal. Wait, what is in this box first?

I look at the box, wondering what exactly is inside it. I pick it up, and try to open it, it doesn't budge. I remember when Father almost gave it to me in Hazelwood he had a small key in his pocket. I run towards Father, lying on the ground. I reach inside his pocket, there it is. I pull the key out and start to tweak it around inside the lock. CLICK! I sit down on the grass. So excited to open it and see what is inside, but also a bit nervous. What if it isn't what I thought? What if it's new school supplies or maybe some more coin? I might as well not open it if it's going to be school supplies. No. I am going to open this box whether I want to or not. I flip open the box, wait a second for my eyes to adjust to the sudden darkness hiding the contents inside. When I see what it is I stumble backwards, grab hold of it and stare. Just stare at it. For it is a dwarven dagger, the most astonishing dagger I've ever seen. Even in all the books and writings. I

take hold of it, swing it a little ways, and sit down. I start to feel very tired now and I don't feel like doing anything at all. I start to lie down, along the grass and flowers, and notice how they blow and move precisely to the breeze's movements. I start to imagine I was a flower, blowing and twirling, dancing to the breeze when sleep overcame me. And I stumbled into a great, deep sleep.

Chapter 6

I rouse up to the sound of crickets and the slow steady breeze, the sun has gone down a fair ways and moonlight has replaced its magnificence. I hear a stirring of shrubberies and turn to the sound towards my left, only to see a squirrel. He looks at me and then turn towards the forest, about to run. I feel a sudden pain in my stomach. I am famished. I glare at the hideous creature, remembering all of Father's famous stews and goods he made with squirrel. I think of all the great recipes he taught me to cook with squirrel. The animal can sense my hunger, and darts off in a flurry! I desperately arise up off the ground and up to my feet. I sprint as fast as I can towards the creature, and the wood. The squirrel scurries through the wreckage; I follow it by going around it as not to burn myself, again.

We flee through wood and field and other items you might find in the wilderness. I try to follow it but it's just too fast. I start to feel like a squirrel myself. Charging through sticks, berries, thick brown trees, shrubberies, bushes, and watching my step amidst the tree roots under my feet as I scamper across them. Berries. I turn back a few steps, examining the big, plump, and juicy balls of juice dangling from a very towering branch, on a tremendously tall tree. I look up the unbelievably tall tree, wondering how delicious those berries are. The red, blue, and yellow coloured berries are all I need right now to feast on. I look up and down the tree for stairs I could walk on. There's none. I don't understand it. Whenever someone needs to go up high for something there are always stairs. I turn to my right side of the tree to see a small, branch, poking out the side of the tree. So I try to jump onto it, and pain sears up my head as I thump my head really hard on another branch. OW! I look up at it, it's just in reach.

I grab hold of it and try to pull myself up. But to no avail. What if I try to use thrust my feet upon that smaller branch by swinging from the one I'm grasping now? I start to pretend I'm running along the ground, except my feet are above the ground. It doesn't work, I don't move an inch. I then try to swing my legs from me, to the branch. I start to swing my legs, it's working. I'm moving them as a pair towards the smaller branch. I propelled my feet in the air, towards the smaller branch, and land them right on the spot. I look at my work and feel very proud of myself. Then realize I'm basically laying down on air because my arms are holding me up like an upside down pushup. My arms are clasping the branch above of me, while my feet are resting on the branch across from me. I look for a safe way up higher. There's another branch just a little ways ahead, a few feet. I then ponder on how to get up from the spot I'm in. I twist and turn, my hands slip, and I fall down with a THUD as I collapse onto the ground. More pain scorches up my back, legs and shoulders.

I look back up to the berries just drooping there, waiting to be eaten. As I think of them anger steams through my skull. Those berries can rot all year if they want I don't care! I start to walk away but as I'm walking away an aroma overcomes me through my nose, my head, stomach, and bones. I stop and stare at the berries, one last time. They look and smell so delightful. I run back to the branches, and leap towards the small branch and grasp the small branch with the tips of my fingers. I let my right hand go, let it dangle a little before I thrust it back up over my head, and fully onto the branch. I redo my grip on my left hand, by letting it hang down like a dead rabbit for a few seconds, allowing it to collect more blood while I pull it back up onto the twig. As I try to pull myself up, I notice a small crack in the twig I'm holding on to. I don't have much time, soon that twig is going to SNAP! And I'm going to tumble back down to where I came from. I look around myself, for any branches that could be of any use. Almost right behind me, directly behind me is a very, very long branch that exceeds my height by more than 2 feet. I let my left hand go, and swing it to the long branch; I clip its edge with my fingertips. I swing my arm back, and recollect my thoughts. After doing nothing at all for a few minutes I swing my hand back again at the long branch and land my hand on it.

I feel some presence in front of me and turn to see the huge tree's bark mere inches from my face. I get an idea; if I scaled the tree, while clasping the branches, I could walk up the tree until I had my feet on the branches, and my arms in length of the berries. I start to feel the tree's trunk with my feet, like a cat would. I then both pull my arms and walk up the tree. I start to get to the point where I can't pull myself

up any longer because my arms are either too short, or I am as high as I can go. I lift my legs, and settle them on the twigs. I immediately hug the tree, not wanting to fall for the height is very dangerous and I'm getting what they call, butterflies on my stomach. I push my hands up and up the tree until I'm standing straight, arm's length of the berries. I lift one hand skyward towards the berries, grab the top stem, and yank them down so hard I nearly lose my balance. I look in the palm of my hand, the berries just, sitting there.

It was too easy, the berries were so high and I never thought I could get them but they're here, in my hand. I can do anything now. But I have to get home. I have to find Hazelwood. I am sure it's not far, saying we only traveled for a day, well a day sitting on a wagon driven by ponies. Well I'm sure I'll find a way. I find a safe way down the tree, and then follow the way I came back to wreckage, chewing on a few berries along the way. For some reason, as I'm walking through this dense forest, I feel as though I'm being watched.

Chapter 7

The berries used to be delicious, but now I'm sick of them because I ate too many, too fast. My stomach ached as I sprinted back to my new shelter, the wreckage. The moon was way to the south by now, it must have been a long trip to have been running half the night. For once I am glad to be running, for in Hazelwood I only ran when the other kids were chasing me, glad I got all the practice. In my journey back to the shelter I was racing time for the day had been long, and Father was still lying on the grass. The moon was setting as I looked towards the wooden mess I called home. *Home*. Has a nice ring to it. I remember home, when every day I would be charging from the school kids, darting this way and that way until I reached the safety of home. That was when life made sense, the good days. Now everything is confusing and wrong. Only one thing stands perfectly clear to me now:

I have to go home, and I have to go now.

I can hear the old crickets still singing their song, for the night was ending quickly. I can hear the embers still burning from the wreckage way underneath all the ash as the smoke swirls up into the sky like a grand staircase. The birds start their song now, for as I read in my studies the birds only fly about during the day, as the crickets take the night. I look towards the only thing I have to take with me, Father. I turn to where his body still laid a carpet against the forests style. I charge as fast as I can towards his side, and collapse against the ground. My legs finally gave way as I went near to his side. The pain from running all night suddenly roars all up through my legs, I scream out in pain for it is searing up and down my whole body now. I can't seem to breathe correctly, and my legs, arms, and hands are so in such agony I can't feel them. I reach over to Father and turn him over to his side to face me. He is still unconscious, but his gaze seems to be, locked, on me. His mouth starts to move, and mumbles! He stares at me, opens his mouth…

Moans, and then collapses again to his unconscious state.

He didn't say much, or anything for that matter, but it was enough for me. I turn around, trying to think of a way to help him, when I get an idea. I run towards the wreckage, and grab old scraps of cloth. After a few minutes of searching, I dart back towards Father. He doesn't look any different, which is not a good thing. I grab his feet and start to drag him over the forest. He is remarkably heavy, about 59 weights more than I thought. As I near the forest line I start to slow down. The ache in my arms is excruciating. With no more than 10 lengths away, I try to push on forwards, by the time I move 2 lengths, I fall down on the grass. After running all night for around eight hours, I was exhausted.

As I was inspecting the area around me I saw a small blur dart from tree to tree, as if it was hiding from someone, or something. It had amazing speed. A small brown blur leaping freely through the forest. I kept watching it, dumbfounded. The blur suddenly stopped in its tracks, and stared at me. It was a fox. A small, brown fox. Its ears were popped right up towards the sky, and its tail always seemed to move like waves from the ocean. It was staring at me, with its tiny eyes. We stood there staring at each other for a few seconds, and the fox went darting again back to the forest it came from.

I am not looking forward to the forest. The huge field was hard enough but to travel in the forest. With all the hard, trees in my path that have their arms swing out in front of me and jab me at all times, while I am dragging Father around. I don't know how I am going to do that. With all the trees and all the thick brush, I am definitely going to get lost. "Unless I use the sun as my guide," I said as I turned towards the sky, not noticing that I hadn't said a word out loud in a long time. As I look ahead to the north as the sun peaks up from over the mountain. The mountain. Yes, I have an idea, if I journey towards the mountain to the north I've got to reach home eventually. Yes, that's what I'm going to do. I walk back towards Father and try to lift him up, which doesn't do anything for me. He is just too heavy. I think of a way to drag him easier, when I remember in my books about a way to drag people safely while making it easier. It's called a stretcher! I get back up off from the ground, loving adrenaline as I run to the nearby trees, and using my dwarven knife I chop down a ton of branches from the trees. After chopping down around ten big branches, I run back to my supply of cloth, after some time tying up the branches together, I could call this either a really small wall, or a door without a handle. I again pull out my dwarven knife,

and cut off all the branches except two on the end for handle bars. I grab the handle bars and drag the stretcher to Father, which is incredibly easier than I earlier thought it would be. After I come up to Father, I pick up his legs, and drop them on the end of the board. Then I grab his torso and push all I can until he's up on the top of the stretcher. I start to pull him to the edge of the forest, and then my legs crumple up from underneath the ground and fall to bits. I put down Father and lay down on the grass.

And I had a well-earned sleep.

Chapter 8

I have no idea how long I slept for, but it was a long time. The sun is starting to set, and I have to get going if I am ever going to return home. As the sky turned reddish pink, which by the way is a remarkably beautiful sight, I picked up Fathers stretcher and started my long journey to the mountain, and home.

I made sure all the things I had were packed; the dagger, Father, and the stretcher. Yes, that about all I had to pack anyway. So as I entered the tree line, I turned back to the field and the crash site, rather relieved to be leaving.

And so I entered the deep and dark forest.

I believe the trees wanted me dead. The sudden pricks and cuts and scratches got exceptionally bothersome after my legs were shaved of their skin. Now of course, they weren't actually bare bones but they could have been if I couldn't feel the small stabs every second or so as the tree's plotted against me. But I'll show them I can run past their traps! The bashes got more and more agonizing I tried to just lift my legs as they scraped past my ankles. I started to get in a melody of, CRUNCH, CRUNCH, and SNAP! CRUNCH, CRUNCH, SNAP! When suddenly the branches started to… rise? Yes. Indeed they were rising to stab my legs as I was starting to enjoy myself. "Curse these trees." I said under my breath, in hope the trees don't hear and-

Pain throbbed in and out of my head as if a boulder flew right into my brain; I fell down on the grass. The ringing started as I massaged the bump on my forehead. The bump gradually got larger and larger, until it was the size as my finger! The ringing was now starting to diminish as I looked up to see a huge thick branch dangling right at the place where my forehead must've been. So the trees did hear me. I used the tree for support as I got up, trying to choke it, but to no avail. I stood back up, trying to hide the most aggravating headache I have ever had as to show the trees that they can't hurt me. As I continued my trek through the trail of hard, pricking, stabbing sticks and rocks. My left foot suddenly felt warm, and wet. I looked down to my foot, only, it wasn't there! I lift up my leg and out of the ground and water splashed all up and down my foreleg. I must have entered a swamp considering the look of the water, dark brown and murky. I look for other signs of a swamp. The forest, swamp, starts to get thicker ahead of me.

Swamps are impossible if you want to stay dry. The next splash trickled down the back of my neck. I had to stop what I was doing and- Splash! My whole body was soaked. I shook myself until I felt decently dry, not that dry in other words. I started to ignore the water as it just kept coming whenever I tried to dry it off. I tried to just ignore it until I was colder than… cold. Then I took my shirt and used that to dry off my hair, it was dripping water onto my face. It could've been worse though, I might've been stuck in the Twin Mountains of the East, where the only water found is stuck in thick ice. Or in the far dessert of Cirm, where there is no water for hundreds of miles. Anyways I still don't like all this water.

As I was trekking through the mostly-water-swamp, I heard a faint groan. I turned to the sound; noticing Father's eyes were open. I immediately lowered and set down the stretcher and crouched beside Father.

"Father? Are you awake?"
He only groaned again, but his head was moving, turning and twisting.

"Father?"

He shifted his head back and forth, and then yawned.

"Hello Philip."

Father lifted his arms and scratched his nose. Then he turned too looked around us.

"Do you know where you're going Philip?"

"Yes Father, if we keep heading this way we'll make it to Hazelwood in no time."

Father kept staring into my eyes.

“How do you know this?”

I should’ve guessed Father would be rather curious to know how I suddenly knew how to get around.

“I could see the Mountain to the north and I know that the Big River is in between us and the mountain somewhere. When we come across it, we just follow the river upwards to Hazelwood.”

He looked as if he was questioning my theory.

“Well, I can't do anything about it since I'm stuck here so I guess you’ve got to be right.” He rubbed his head, “Besides I feel rather woozy and I can't really think.”

Right before I could speak my ears shattered! A gigantic roar echoed through the forest from all angles, the trees shivered, the water rippled, and I nearly fell off my feet! Father held onto the edges of his stretcher as if it were about to fly up in the air any second! Then from the North, a massive crash emitted far, far away. Then all was silent, and Father looked at me while my ears were still ringing.

“Philip, I am going to slip back to the darkness again, but you have to know that is the sound of a giant, you have to hurry because if we meet this giant, I don’t know what’ll happen to us. We’ll probably die. You have to hurry.”

He fell unconscious as he finished.

I looked in the direction of the sound. There were only trees as far as the eye can see. But, I saw that small and tiny fox, glaring at me once again from the corner of my eye before it scurried off into the thick trees.

That fox has been following me for a while now.

Chapter 9

The wet, thick swamp is starting to dry up.

That's what I kept thinking as the wet layer of muck got thinner and thinner, making a point that I am leaving the swamp. The fox has been quietly keeping up to me, making shivers scuttle up and down my spine. The swamp finally came to a clearing… showing a small hill directly ahead of me. I just left the swamp when I noticed the blinding light. I couldn't see ahead of myself a length! I covered my eyes with my arms until they conditioned themselves to the extreme brightness. When they eventually did condition themselves I noticed the fox standing right beside me. It started to brush itself against my leg as we walked. The grass was so soft, softer than the grass in the clearing where I awaken.

I stopped and gathered my senses as the fox took its seat in the grass directly ahead of me. It looked as if it wanted to talk to me, with its head perched to the side.

"Well, who are you?"

The fox did not answer.

"If you have any secret hideout with a lifetime supply of food, which would be awesome, could you lead the way?"

The fox didn't answer, but kept on walking beside me, all the while keeping its gaze on me like a sharp eagle.

"You know, if you caught a deer recently…"

The fox stopped walking, and I turned around to gaze into its eyes too.

"Can you understand me?"

The fox simply perched its head again.

"If you know where food is," I made an eating signal by putting my hands in my mouth, like a sandwich.

"Then please tell me."

I had to massage my eyes for a second, but did the fox really just wink at me? If so, then he could understand me, which means it may know where food is, which is good, very good.
"Where is all the food?"

The fox started to take small steps towards me.

"If you do not know by now my Father needs help. So any food would be appreciated."

The fox was a length away, as he was slowly approaching, anger swelled up in me. This fox is just trying to slow me down.

"Ok you stupid good-for-nothing dumb hairball! I don't need any help I can do this on my own without any sheepish foxes chasing me!"

I took off. Running as fast as I could while Father was bumping along behind me up the hill. The hill was larger as I got closer and closer, making my climb not as enjoyable. The grass was rich green, green enough to engulf the whole land if it really wanted to. My legs ached as the hill got taller and taller, when suddenly they gave way and I lay beside Father on the hill. I remembered when I was back in my home, in my bed, staring at the ceiling, when suddenly my bed started to shake, then move, then turn and flip around! I hit my face against Father's shoulder. I got up and felt a wisp of softness on my ankle again, I looked down and saw that fox again, innocently gazing up at me. I had to get over this hill, and then I could rest. I leapt back to my running place in front of Father and picked up my pace once again, only it was a bit easier this time. I turned back to see how far I've come up the hill, it was a little more than half,

when I saw the fox pushing Father with me.

“Thank you fox, I need the help.”

I kept on running up the hill, with all my strength.

“I'm not a hairball.”

I stopped. I thought I just heard someone. I turned behind me, it was just the fox. I kept on walking up the hill.

“And my name’s Filroy. Filroy Foxman.”

I stopped. I slowly turned to see the fox.

“Did, did you just… talk?”

The fox perched its head to the side again and opened its mouth.

“Yep! My name is Filroy Foxman.”

I didn’t do anything, couldn’t do anything.

“Um, I apologize for being rude.”

I continued heading up the hill, stunned.

“Well you are forgiven.”

“Uh, thanks.”

“Yeah you know how you asked if I had caught a deer recently?”

I immediately turned back around.

“Yes? What is it?”

“I haven’t caught one for a week.”

I had the biggest sigh of my life.

“Don’t worry though, after the giant leaves the deer will return.”

“What are you talking about?” I kept on walking.

“The giant, big, tall, huge, chomps trees and crushes rocks!” He said with a small laugh hidden in his voice.

“I know what a giant is,” I said with a smirk.

“Hah! I thought so. This giant has been stomping around and scaring off all the deer, I was busy snatching up all the remaining bugs and squirrels when I saw you trying to catch one, right then I knew you were new to hunting.”

“Yeah for a bit there I was in deep trouble.”

“Hah no kidding! In fact that squirrel was really good.”

“You ate my squirrel?!?” I said in astonishment.

“Oh yeah, later on it got stuck in a mess of twigs and thorns. I pretty much just snapped its –

“I'm good I don’t need details.” I interrupted the fox.

“Thanks because I really don’t feel like repeating it.”

I laughed a little. Seemed like the first time in years.

“You can call me Mr. Fox”

I stopped climbing and faced him,

“Nice to meet you Mr. Fox, my name is Philip.”

“Pleased to meet you Philip.”

“Same to you.”

I walked a little and found I was on the top of the hill, overlooking what used to be a forest and fields but now just a field of holes and ashes.

The fox seemed to gesture by the look on his face that it was the giant. I agree with the fox. We started our trek down the other side of hill.

“Well what brings you to the deep forest in the first place?”

“I never wanted to be here.” I said as I shrugged my shoulders, not really making a point because the weight of Father really made my shoulders become numb.

“Well then… Why are you here?” The fox said curiously.

The hillside very suddenly got steeper for a second, and Father started to slide down the hill, as you would slide down hills up in the north, where it snows.

“Father and I were traveling to Malcore, but our wagon collapsed and rolled down the cliff side, I blacked out as we were falling and I woke up at the bottom of the cliff, the field you were watching me in.”

“Aahh… I see. Yes that cliff is rather steep.” The fox said.

We kept hiking.

“Well at least I have a friend to talk to.” I said, feeling a breeze chill my forelegs and arms.

I turned around, looking for the origin of the cold. I saw a great darkness behind me, smeared along the ground and striking like a grand hammer. The storm had arrived.

Chapter 10

As soon as the breeze chilled me, several things happened at once.

First, the fox immediately scurried off ahead of me, fleeing from the storm. Second, the tree's all looked as if they had fallen down, then were only staying in one place because of their deep, old roots. Then I heard an awful roar, sounded like an army of war-orcs chanting all at once. Then it hit me, literally hit me. I dropped as soon as the sound burst, but I was too late. I was sent flying through the air, like an arrow. It was only a few lengths, but it felt like I was flying way past the country I know of, over strange lands. I saw a streak of pure light spill past me and enter the earth. Right then I realized I was heading downwards. I saw the earth come close, and braced for impact.

THUMP!

I tumbled down the hill, rolling and rolling and rolling, spinning, revolving, rotating, and swaying down the hill. My eyes ached. My head hurt! I flung my arms to my head, trying to protect it from the thumping along the ground. Suddenly I hit something with my side, and I stopped rolling. But my head wasn't done yet. I tried to stand up, tried. I toppled over again and my jaw was incredibly sore. I sat there for a second, and felt my shirt; I don't usually feel my shirt unless I was soaked. I looked down at my shirt, yep, it was soaked. I glanced up in the sky, and couldn't spot the clouds there was such a bombard of rain splashing in my eyes. I tilted my head downwards to hide from the falling water as the wind tore at my face and body, clawing as it swept along the grass. The wind was nothing compared to the lightning. And if I haven't informed you beforehand, the lightning is very, very fatal.

I shook as the thought of lightning entered my head. I charged towards Father, who was lying in the grass near the edge if the wet slope. His stretcher was on top of him. I bolted up the hill a few lengths, fighting against the unforgiving wind. The few seconds it should take to get to Father lasts about a minute. When I do reach him I immediately cover him with the stretcher, hoping it'll help shield him from some of the rain, at least. The storm doesn't let me off the hook as it picks me up and throws me down the hill, towards the swamp. I view the tumbling scene in my mind, waiting for the-

THUMP!

I wasn't prepared for it. I flung my arms out, like a puppet with no master. The grass stung as it scraped through my legs and arms. I form into a ball, rolling down more or less at this point. I open my eyes, straining because the spinning is holding them closed, every time I am in the correct position my eyes are free, for a moment, but when they are I can see the trees hurtling towards me.

I rolled until my feet hit the side of the hill, then I dug them into the ground, my toes hurt from all the pressure. Immediately my torso flung into the air, I stood there for a split-second, and then fell onto by back. My head was dizzy as I gazed up the hill from the ground. The world span, my head throbbed, and I was stuck to the ground. Not from any weight or pressure, but the weakness throughout my body. I couldn't move my hand up to block the rain from hitting my face. I feel like just laying here, forget all the school I have, forget all the work I'll have to do when I'm older. What if I just, laid here forever? Right then I felt a small bump, tapping my shoulder. I turned my eyes to my left, to see the fox. He looked at me as if he knew what I was thinking. He tugged on a piece of wood. I looked behind him to see the stretcher! He pulled the stretcher down the hill and under a tree, and then returned to me. He pushed my shoulder and I got up, walked down to the tree, sat down, and watched the rain fall down to my feet until the darkness consumed me.

And I slept.

Chapter 11

I didn't sleep for long. I awoke to a sound, I don't remember it, but I knew it was there a second ago.

I got up from the tree, and couldn't feel, or hear rain. The sun was rising; I felt the calm emotion of peace, as the leaves from the trees floated through the air. I walked out to the opening, right under the hill. There wasn't a hint of fear. But of ease, floating in about the falling leaves. The leaves didn't want to touch the ground as they glided about, soaring this way and that. Then suddenly there were more leaves, and more. They formed a whole as they assembled a mass host. Then they were all falling to the ground. They were falling much faster than before, and a cold chill seemed to elevate from, everywhere. Then I heard a large SWOOSH! I looked ahead of me, and saw a tree had fallen to the ground. I followed its trunk to the roots, where a giant foot lay. I held my breath, and looked up, about 20 lengths away from me, and about 15 lengths high, stood a giant. It was a huge and ugly thing. It glared at me. I was so terrified I couldn't move. It picked up its foot and crushed the tree it must have smashed down, the sound I must have heard was its roar. It looked at me, than lifted its other foot, slowly approaching me. I couldn't move I just stood there, watching it. It had the angriest face I've ever seen. It kept heading towards me, and I just stood there. It was about 15 lengths away, and its arms looked as if they were about 9 lengths long. If it wanted to it could grab me right now. That's when it woke me up. I took off in the opposite direction of Father, hoping it won't notice him.

There were a few trees that were taller than the giant. As I headed towards the tree, I felt a breeze behind me and was swept up by a huge hand! I felt the wind glide past me to wherever it needed to go. The hand let go of me in midair, and I felt weightless. I saw the ground speeding towards me, wait, me speeding towards the ground! Right now there was no peace flowing through me. Only fear, worry, and stress. I hit the ground and rolled onto Father! I quickly got back up, grabbed the dwarven knife, and took off again towards the far trees, I guess the giant had an idea of what I was going to do because he went and stood right in my path. It grabbed the tree it tore down earlier and threw it to me. The tree spun as it soared through the sky, right towards me. I ran to the edge of the tree line and the end of the tree smashed into the tree line as I entered the wood with a large CRUNCH! I rolled under tree. Waiting for the giant to leave, thinking I'm dead. The ground shakes as it walks. I can feel it coming closer. The stomps are getting louder. I grab hold of a few branches, ready to push my way out if needed. The weight on my arms was unbearable! I looked down only to see, the ground, 8 lengths away! I let my legs dangle as the giant inspected his new tree. He lifted it above his head, I knew it was my chance, I let go, fell towards the giants head, and landed on its shoulders! I grabbed onto his face and with my legs wrapped myself around its neck, squeezing tightly. I let one arm go to reach my knife; I held it up high in the air-

And the giant leaned forward, way too far. I fell downward to the grass. I landed really smooth this time, and got up in an instant. The giant lost its balance too, and collapsed to the hard packed dirt. I was up and charging to it before the giant knew he fell. I jumped onto its shoulder again, wrapped myself around its neck, raised the knife and struck its skull!

Only, the giants head was… rock.

I hurt my hand more than the giant, if the giant felt anything. It reached up and tried to pick me up with its right hand. I reacted and stabbed its shoulder. It hollered in pain. I lifted the knife high in the air again and lunged at its other shoulder! It knelt down on both knees. I took one arm and held its forehead high, then took the knife, let my legs go, and plunged it into the giant's neck, I heard an ugly sound of tearing and ripping, and so I pulled the knife out, and stabbed again! The giant's neck was spraying blood all over! It was like crushing a tomato, only a lot of tomatoes. It fell forward, and I pulled out the knife, rolled off the giant, and got up to see it crash down on the ground. I looked at the knife; it wasn't as shiny so I rubbed it against the grass, passing on the blood of the giant. I wiped it on my clothes, sat down.

And darkness overcame me, and I slept.

Chapter 12

I awoke to the greatest sight in the world. The fox was sitting there beside me, Father still lay there on his stretcher, and the sun was just rising through the trees. And past the hill, lay a stone tower. I couldn't tell you how happy I was to see that tower. It was a simple, but elegant, stone brick tower. It was tower of Malcore, the great city. It was about a half days walk, so I immediately stood up, grabbed the stretcher, and started walking.

I don't know how I didn't recognize it before, probably the storm, but I'm glad I saw it now.

As I came up on the peak of the hill I saw it, Malcore, bigger and better than ever. Its stunning and outstanding splendour shimmered through the sky like the sun. My eyes started blurring, and I noticed my stomach was, empty. I had to be fast, before I starved to death.

SNAP!

I turned around to see the fox.

"Hey sorry, just stepped on a twig."

I laughed for a moment, because for a second I thought the giant had returned.

"Its fine, you just jumped me."

I darted down the hill, pulling Father along. He hardly bumped I was sprinting so fast. I ran to the road, stopped… and looked at the stairs that lay ahead of me, all of them rather steep. They led up to a giant wall made of thick rock, each stone gathered from deep within the Twin Mountains. The elegant towers on each corner looked like ugly barns compared to the tower of Malcoreigh. The gold tower gazed over the entire city and kept it bright. The leader of the city dwelled in there and made the city laws in there. In fact I heard that Malcore grew from a small, bandit tower that some nobles took over long ago, and over time turned to the great city of Malcore.

As I thought of Malcore, I turned back to the stairs, all thirty of them. This is going to be a hard climb.

I noticed the adrenaline leave and the pain return as I came to the stairs, my eyes were sore, my legs ached every step, my head throbbed, and my stomach sent waves of hunger up and through my body, snatching away all the remaining strength I had.

As I came to the stone steps, I stumbled and fell on my knee. The pain in my legs is excruciating. I pull myself upright, and start climbing. Step after step. And each step my legs take sends yet even more pain up my body. I start to feel dizzy, and my already grave vision becomes worse. I climb higher, faster, and swifter up every step!

I stop.

Not because of the serious pain telling me to roll over and die, but the large wooden doors blocking my path.

I swipe my hand on the door, looking for a groove, and pull. Nothing happens. What if they won't open the doors? What if I am forced to live in the wilderness forever? What if I am going to die in the forest? What if I'm too late? I start shaking the doors, banging the doors, pounding the doors, when I hear a click. A small click.

I turn to the fox, but he wasn't there, no signs of him, at all.

Father still lay there, slowly breathing.

I turn to the doors, and feel the energy run up my spine as I shiver.

"Here we go father."

I take a deep breath.

I feel the door, lightly press on the groove, open the door, and walk into Malcore.

I did it.

THE END